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The Different Faces of the Cold War : Middle East

The term "Arab Cold War" was first used by Malcolm H. Kerr, an American political scientist and Middle East scholar, in his 1965 book of the same name and subsequent edition. We cannot simply define the Cold War, as the rivalry between two superpowers, in one continent that is Europe. In that time, the Middle East became one of the most strategic and contested territories. As Fred Halliday (2005) notes, the region became a "*mirror and microcosm*" of the Cold War's global dynamics — a space where ideology, military power, and economic interests intertwined. The main thesis of this essay will try to see the strategic importance of this region, that is due to ideology, proxy conflicts, and economic competition, and that we can still see effects of these dynamics nowadays in this crucial region, for geopolitics. However, instead of tackling all this broad subject of the Cold War dynamics as a whole, we will tackle four local dynamics : ideological rivalries, rise of Arab Nationalism, economic and political competition, in a bipolar world, and how these dynamics changed the future of the region.

I. Ideological Rivalries and the Rise of Arab Nationalism

We have to go back to historical roots, of the post second world war era. The retreat of French, English and more globally European powers in the region, created a real vacuum of power. Therefore, the political sphere is more than uncertain in a time where a new global conflict rises. As Westad state, both superpower, used this region, in the dynamics of global contest, for influence. (Westad, 2005). However both superpowers don't have the same goals : The United States, tend to secure commercial routes, such as the Suez Canal, while the Soviet Union, are in a "war" against imperialism, in a more ideological expansion (Gerges, 1994). Based on this, I thought it important to talk about Arab Nationalism, which emerged in kind of a "third way" between Western domination and Soviet 'Imperialism'. Under the leadership of the Egyptian President Nasser, we find this as an example of anti-imperialism and soviet domination. In this example, we see all the dynamics of the cold war, in dynamics such as, anti-colonialism, for the arab world, panarabism, and a very specific arab socialism. However, the participation in the Bandung Conference in 1955, and the rise of the non-aligned movement, did not tackle this dynamic, where Egypt, and I would say the Arab World,rise, in this post-cold war area as a model : The ideological rivalry is mingled with *realpolitik*. However, Egypt, more and more, slided in the Soviet sphere of influence, when the U.S, refused to finance the Aswan dam, and leading to the 1955 deal with Czechoslovakia, proof that the Ideological rivalries, went far more than into only the Arab world. (Kerr, 1971). One year later, Ideological Rivalries, joined a pinnacle, when Nasser nationalized the Suez Canal, and as a consequence, Britain, France and Israël invaded the zone. Under US and Soviet pressure, the invaders were forced to withdraw — a humiliation that exposed the end of European dominance and the rise of bipolar control in the region. (Laron, 2017). The term, *Arab Cold War*, theorized by Kerr, therefore made all the sense : the Middle East is in the center of world politics, because, crisis, to be solutionned, needs both superpowers. I would argue that the 60's represented the embedded position of conflicts in the region always being overseen by the two hegemon. First, the US started backing the conservative monarchies, like Jordania, Saudi Arabia and even Iran, before the revolution of

1979, while USSR, backed up by Charles Tripp, called Revolutionary Republics, like Egypt, Syria and Irak. (Tripp, 2007.) But, how can we explain the apparent 'docility' of the Arab countries ? My opinion, and backed up by Fred Hallyday (2005), already cited in introduction, the divided Arab world, allowed both superpowers, while local leaders pursue their own politics, to influence the politics of the region. For me, even though we have a divided Arab world, we have to abandon this idea, that the Middle East was a passive actor, in this cold war era. The Cold War era was indeed influenced, by global superpowers, but shaped, by the own states themselves. However, how are these dynamics reflected in the region ?

II. Proxy Conflicts and the Militarization of the Cold War

The Middle East became one of the most militarized regions in the world. Therefore, we can already question this statement of the Arab *Cold War,* by Malcolm H. Kerr. The Arab-Israeli wars were one example. Following the *Guerre des Six Jours,* The United States of America, became the most important allie for Israeli forces, while USSR, backed arms, for Egypt and Syria. (Larron, 2017). During the Yom Kippur War, in 1973, US and USSR, both supplied military help and weapons, to Israel and Arab armies. And, only with the statement made by Westad, we see it was at this moment, that both superpowers claimed the nuclear threat, that we see that the Middle East, powder keg, can threaten "global peace" (Westad, 2005). Therefore 'special operations' in which we understand proxy conflicts, coups, and covert operations, became a tool of influence. This can be clearly seen, in Iran, with the CIA and MI6 coup, to overthrow Prime Minister Mossadegh, who 'dared' to nationalize the Anglo-Iranian Oil company, replaced by a pro-american shah (Kinzer & Schlesinger, 1982). Moscow is no stranger to the same operations. In 1958, the Iraqi Revolution, aligned Baghdad with Moscow. As Louise Fawcett (2022) article points out, such interventions demonstrated how Cold War tensions manifested in local power conflicts instead of direct military clashes between the superpowers. However, we cannot finish this part on militarization, without speaking of Afghanistan, a ten years long war (79-89). The Soviet invasion triggered a Saudi and American operation, to arm the Mujahideen, as an anti-communism operation who would later turn against them. But the late 60's marked also a turning point in the region, being the region of the world with the most armament, and with both superpowers having basis, creating dependence.

III. Economic and Political Dimensions of the CW

However, this broad case study, that we try to do, could not be complete without seeing how important the economic and political dimension of the Cold War, in this region. The Cold War also expressed itself in this region, through economic rivalry, embargoes, and oil war. As the research, in Durham University, Joe Painter depicted, for the U.S, ensuring a continuous access to oil in this region,was indeed a matter of national security and interest. (Painter, 2012). In this sense, and from the beginning of the Cold War, the Roosevelt-Ibn Saud meeting at the end of World War II, sealed the Western Energy policy regarding oil. (Vitalis, 2006). The United States, having moved a pawn, the USSR, will try to do the same, to avoid an hegemonic power in the region, in a more economic way, sealing deals with producer

countries, such as Libya and Iraq. However, 1973 represented a shift point in International Relations in this region, making a new face to the Cold War in the region. The 1973 Oil Embargo, imposed by the OPEP (Arab countries) in response to US support in the Israeli military operation, revealed that oil can be much more than a ressource, and transform into a geopolitical tool, and weapon. Louise Fawcett's article highlights how this moment shifted the global balance of power, demonstrating that regional actors could challenge both Western dominance and Cold War bipolarity. However, and in a more subtile way, economic rivalry also, extend beyond oil, and for me this represent a more subtle way to show face of the cold war in this region, as a contingent of Western influence, but also, shaping the future of the region, with regarding the aid programs, and the duality between modernity and dependency, which are not always shown, as a crucial factors to understand the different faces of the cold war, in the region. In this example, we clearly see the definition of *power and superpower,* given by Serge Sur, *"The capacity to do, to make others do, to prevent doing, and to refuse to do."* This definition is inspired by Raymond Aron, and his book *Paix et Guerres entre les Nations,* and retaken by Serge Sur, and highlights that power is not limited to direct action, but also includes influence through coercion and indirect influence. (Sur, 2021, 7th ed. + Aron, 1962). This is a clear face of the Cold War. The United States, launched programs, such as the Point Four Program in 1949, and supported the pro-occidental White Revolution in Iran, with industrialization. On the other hand, the USSR, launched infrastructure projects, such as de Aswann Dam, in Egypt, and industrial complexes, in Syria and Iraq. (Owen, Pamuk, 1999). These projects, more than being economical, were above all, permitted to consolidate the bipolar system in the region, with economical pressure. This is only the beginning of clientelism in the region, but with one difference from other regions such as Europe : the Middle East, compared to Asia, to Europe, and Africa for example, conserved a certain type of autonomy, which makes the region, for me, special. We clearly see the dynamics of the Cold War, but used in a very pragmatic foreign policy, and used, as a rhetorical tool, for internal stability. Pragmacy, also, finds a place in the shifting alliances, as we see for example in Egypt, during the decade of the 70's. Under Al-Saddat, it turned to the west, being the first Arab state, "normalizing" relations with the unique non-Arab state of the region : Israël. The Camp David accords, in 1978, followed by the first Peace Treaty of the Region, with the forever enemy Israel, paved the way to other States, such as Saudi Arabia, or Iran, to turn towards Washington. The goal was to extract financial benefit. To sum up this part, I will just quote a statement by Louise Fawcett, a real pioneer in the study of International Relations in the Middle East. She writes : *"it was a region where local leaders exploited global rivalries to pursue national and regional ambitions"* (Fawcett, 2022)

But how about today ? Is the dynamics of the Cold War still present nowadays?

IV. What Legacy ?

The end of the Cold War did not erase geopolitical continuity on the contrary. It's shaped what we know nowadays as the Middle East (MENA), with economic legacies, ideological changes, and geopolitical continuities. The US–Saudi strategic alliance, the persistence of the Arab–Israeli conflict, and Russia's renewed influence in Syria all trace their origins to Cold War alignments (Khalidi, 2004; Fawcett, 2022). The Assad dynastie (Hafez

and Bachar) or Saddam Hussein power in Iraq, consolidated their authoritarian power, thanks to cold war dynamics and alliance. Also, economic patterns of the 50's and 60's such as dependency, are still very much important nowadays. And what about Golf Petromonarchies ? With Western protection, they consolidate an economic model, inherited from the Cold War, with oil as a central pillar of the economy and exportation. Ideology is also near. Figures like Ayatollah Khamenei, redefined the ideological sphere of the Middle East, post 1979 Revolution, and built a doctrine that we very much see nowadays : anti-imperialism, challenging pre-existing structures. The US and its allies promoted Islam as a counterweight to socialism and communism, particularly during the Soviet–Afghan War (1979–1989), when the *mujahideen* were valorized as freedom fighters (Coll, 2004). Similarly, the Afghan war facilitated the growth of *jihad* networks that later evolved into global movements. The main consequences I would say, would also be the rise, of a phenomenon, that we try to understand, but it's still blurred for us, occidental : Political Islam. The failure of State building and the Soviet War in Afghanistan, created a movement, inherited from the Cold War, rooted in the idea of *Jihad,* and growing as a global movement. This movement, inherited from the failure of legitimacy of the secular regimes, post cold war, will later be transformed into a global worldwide movement, threatening world order and questioning global order. The global language of opposition, would be, in the post cold war era, the political islam, that cannot be explained without ideology, cold war and economical pressure of external powers. However, we kept the last, but not the least argument for the end of our essay : What social legacy can we find in this Cold War era in the region ? Can we say that the crisis of legitimacy of political systems started here ?

Clearly, the rhetorical tools of *Thawra (*revolution*)* and *istiqlāl (*independence*)* are no longer useful, only twenty years after, political promises of Panarabism, and Social States. During the Cold War era, throughout the Cold War, both monarchies supported by the West and republics aligned with the Soviets justified their governance via ideological conflict, portraying themselves as protectors of national sovereignty against imperialism or communism (Halliday, 2005; Fawcett, 2022). By the 1980s, this bipolar model failed to connect with people experiencing economic difficulties, oppression, and increasing social disparities.

To conclude this essay, the Middle East was far more than a passive arena of the Cold War: it was one of its central battlegrounds, where global rivalries met local ambitions of power. In this sense, and as we tried to underline in the essay, the term *Arab Cold War,* takes all the meaning, as a very special region during the second part of the 20th century. Ideological struggles, proxy wars, and the control of oil made the region a strategic hinge of bipolar competition. However, and it's clear when we see the dynamics nowadays, the Cold War was only the beginning of this phenomenon in the region, changing shapes and forms. There is still nowadays, a crisis of legitimacy, rise of political islam, political extremism, and cold war heritage, in the presence of the U.S and Russia in this region.

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